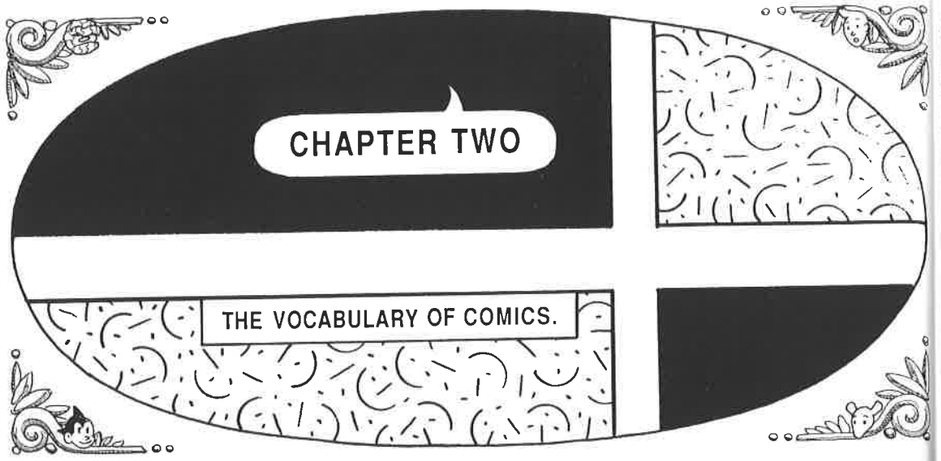
"You must read this book." —Neil Gaiman

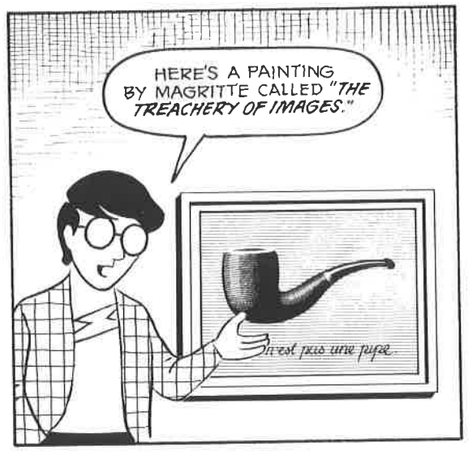
Understanding Comics

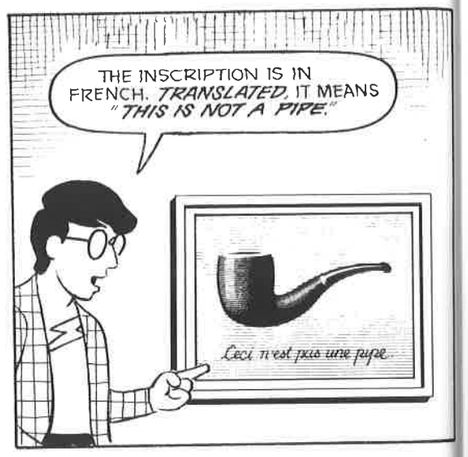
THE INVISIBLE ART

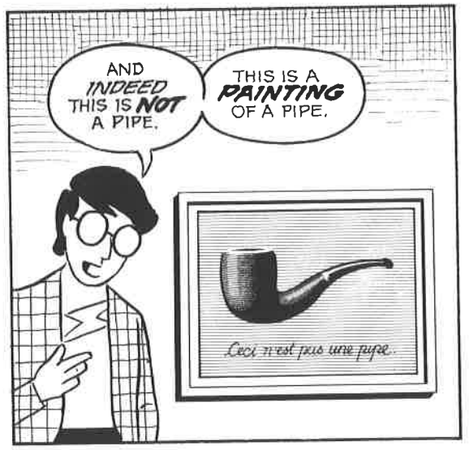
#1 *New York Times* bestselling author

Scott McCloud

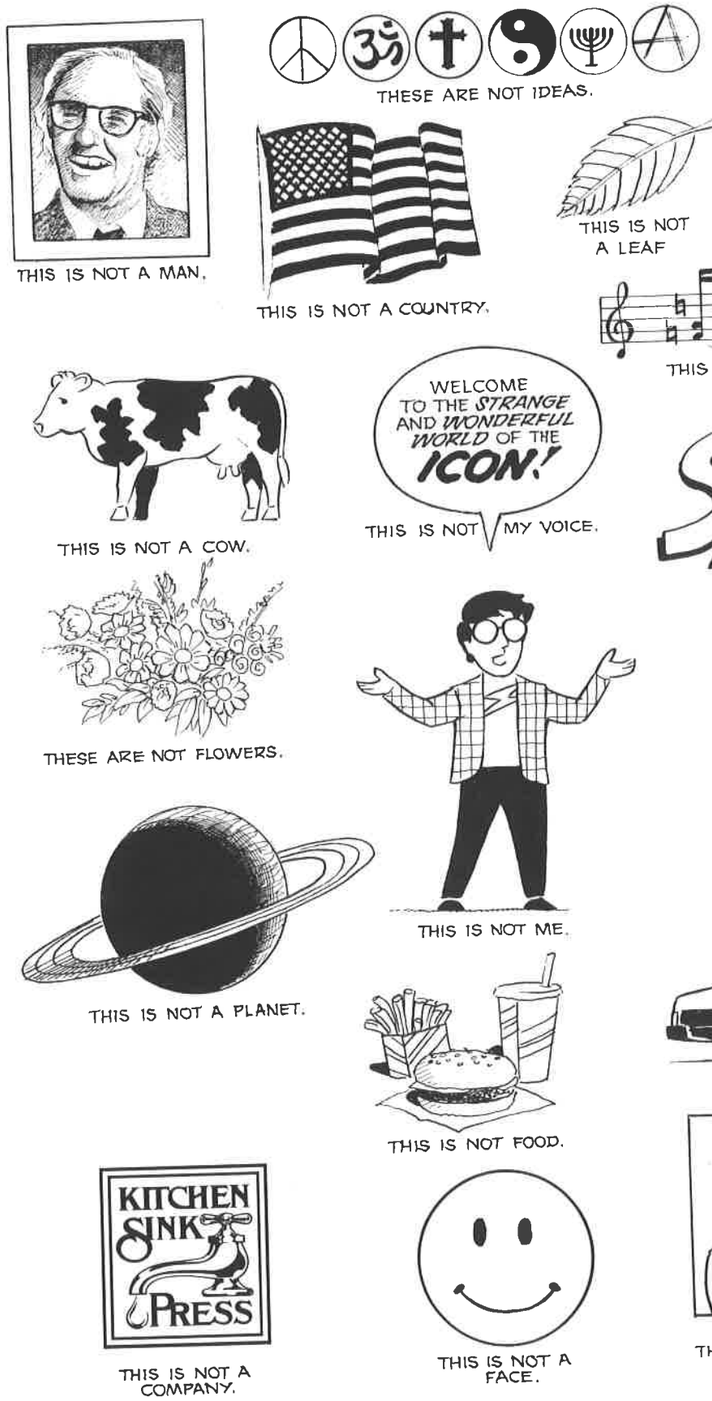


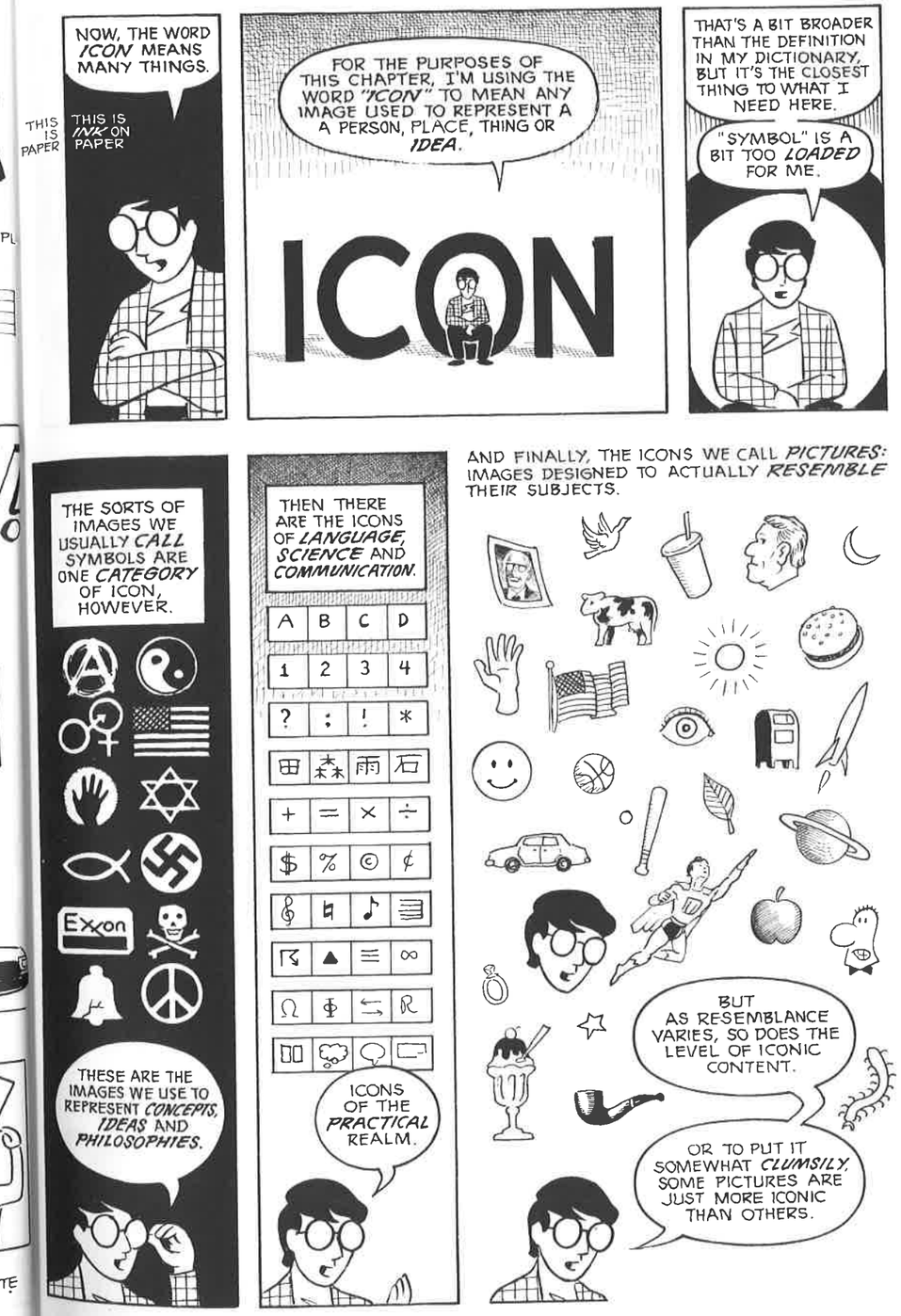


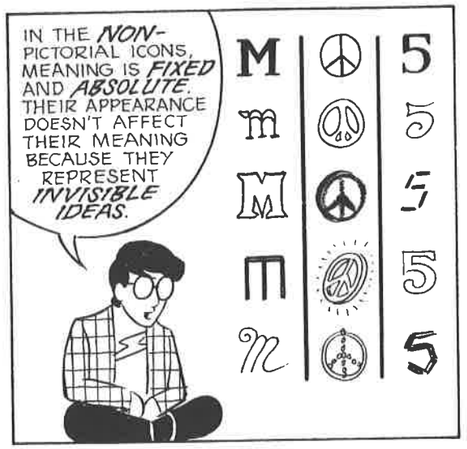




SEE PAGE 216 FOR MORE INFORMATION.


THIS IS NOT A MAN.
THESE ARE NOT IDEAS.
THIS IS NOT A COUNTRY.
THIS IS NOT A LEAF
THESE ARE NOT PEOPL
THIS IS NOT MUSIC.
THIS IS NOT A COW.
WELCOME TO THE STRANGE AND WONDERFUL WORLD OF THE ICON!
THIS IS NOT MY VOICE.
SPLAT!
THIS IS NOT SOUND.
THESE ARE NOT FLOWERS.
STOP
THIS IS NOT LAW.
THIS IS NOT ME.
THIS IS NOT A PLANET.
THIS IS NOT FOOD.
THIS IS NOT A CAR.
KITCHEN SINK PRESS
THIS IS NOT A COMPANY.
THIS IS NOT A FACE.
THESE ARE NOT SEPARATE MOMENTS.


NOW, THE WORD ICON MEANS MANY THINGS.
THIS IS INK ON PAPER
THIS IS PAPER
FOR THE PURPOSES OF THIS CHAPTER, I'M USING THE WORD "ICON" TO MEAN ANY IMAGE USED TO REPRESENT A A PERSON, PLACE, THING OR IDEA.
ICON
THAT'S A BIT BROADER THAN THE DEFINITION IN MY DICTIONARY, BUT IT'S THE CLOSEST THING TO WHAT I NEED HERE.
"SYMBOL" IS A BIT TOO LOADED FOR ME.
THE SORTS OF IMAGES WE USUALLY CALL SYMBOLS ARE ONE CATEGORY OF ICON, HOWEVER.
Exxon
THESE ARE THE IMAGES WE USE TO REPRESENT CONCEPTS, IDEAS AND PHILOSOPHIES.
THEN THERE ARE THE ICONS OF LANGUAGE, SCIENCE AND COMMUNICATION.
A B C D
1 2 3 4
ICONS OF THE PRACTICAL REALM.
AND FINALLY, THE ICONS WE CALL PICTURES: IMAGES DESIGNED TO ACTUALLY RESEMBLE THEIR SUBJECTS.
BUT AS RESEMBLANCE VARIES, SO DOES THE LEVEL OF ICONIC CONTENT.
OR TO PUT IT SOMEWHAT CLUMSILY, SOME PICTURES ARE JUST MORE ICONIC THAN OTHERS.


IN THE NON-PICTORIAL ICONS, MEANING IS FIXED AND ABSOLUTE. THEIR APPEARANCE DOESN'T AFFECT THEIR MEANING BECAUSE THEY REPRESENT INVISIBLE IDEAS.

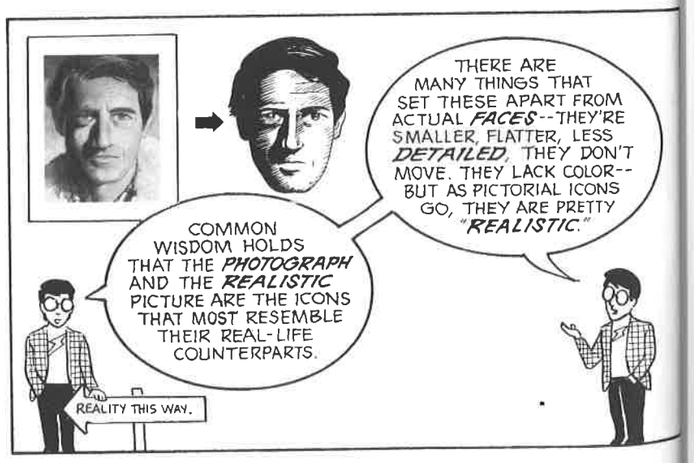
IN PICTURES, HOWEVER, MEANING IS FLUID AND VARIABLE ACCORDING TO APPEARANCE. THEY DIFFER FROM "REAL-LIFE" APPEARANCE TO VARYING DEGREES.

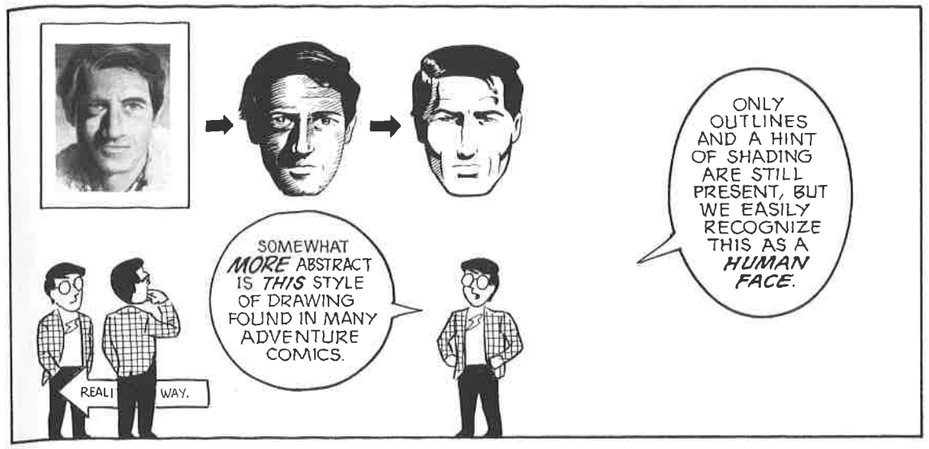
WORDS ARE TOTALLY ABSTRACT ICONS. THAT IS, THEY BEAR NO RESEMBLANCE AT ALL TO THE REAL McCOY.
EYE

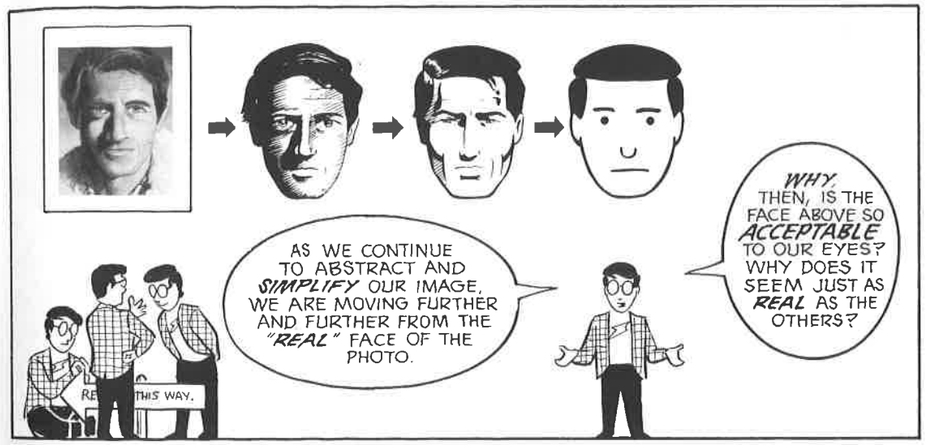
BUT IN PICTURES THE LEVEL OF ABSTRACTION VARIES. SOME, LIKE THE FACE IN THE PREVIOUS PANEL, SO CLOSELY RESEMBLE THEIR REAL-LIFE COUNTERPARTS AS TO ALMOST TRICK THE EYE!

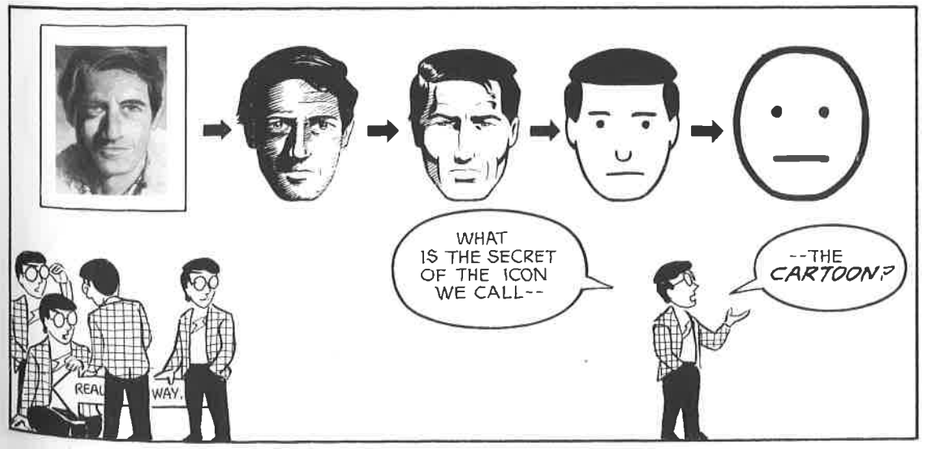
OTHERS, LIKE YOURS TRULY, ARE QUITE A BIT MORE ABSTRACT AND, IN FACT, ARE VERY MUCH UNLIKE ANY HUMAN FACE YOU'VE EVER SEEN!

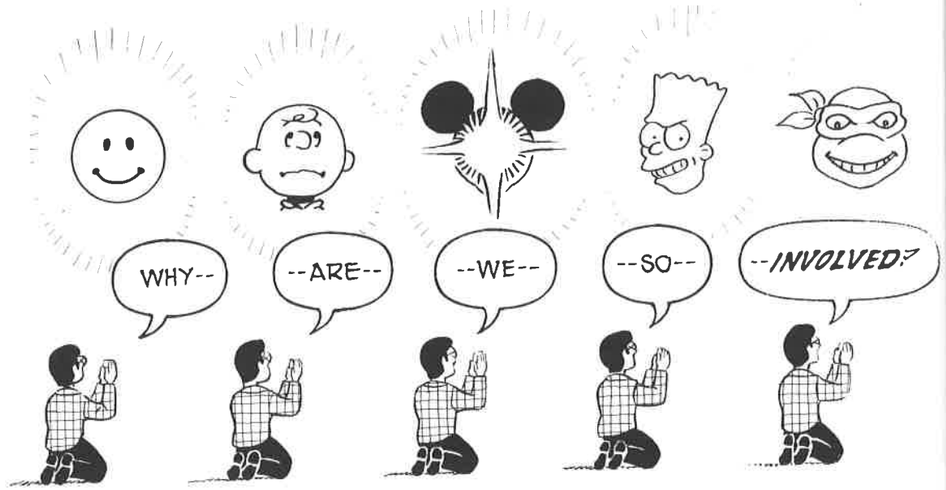
LET'S SEE IF WE CAN PUT THESE PICTORIAL ICONS IN SOME SORT OF ORDER.

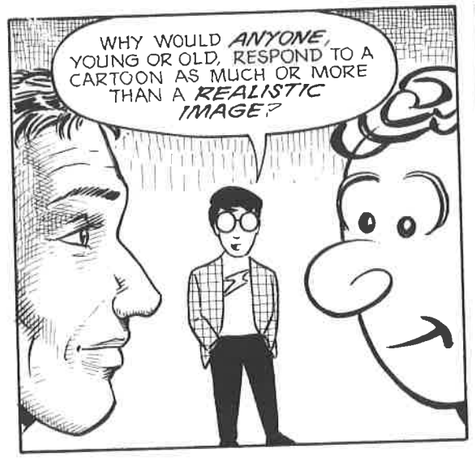

COMMON WISDOM HOLDS THAT THE PHOTOGRAPH AND THE REALISTIC PICTURE ARE THE ICONS THAT MOST RESEMBLE THEIR REAL-LIFE COUNTERPARTS.
THERE ARE MANY THINGS THAT SET THESE APART FROM ACTUAL FACES--THEY'RE SMALLER, FLATTER, LESS DETAILED, THEY DON'T MOVE. THEY LACK COLOR--BUT AS PICTORIAL ICONS GO, THEY ARE PRETTY "REALISTIC."
REALITY THIS WAY.

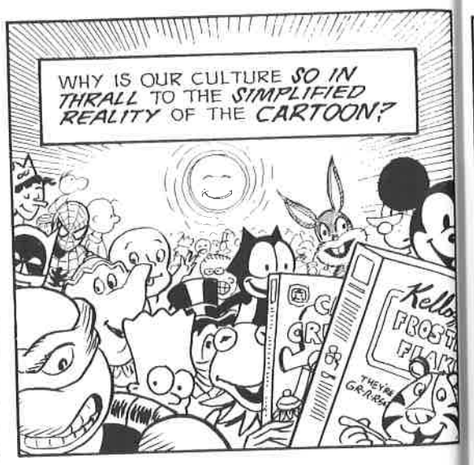

ONLY OUTLINES AND A HINT OF SHADING ARE STILL PRESENT, BUT WE EASILY RECOGNIZE THIS AS A HUMAN FACE.
SOMEWHAT MORE ABSTRACT IS THIS STYLE OF DRAWING FOUND IN MANY ADVENTURE COMICS.
REALI
WAY.

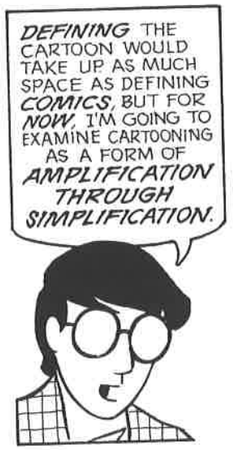

WHY, THEN, IS THE FACE ABOVE SO ACCEPTABLE TO OUR EYES? WHY DOES IT SEEM JUST AS REAL AS THE OTHERS?
AS WE CONTINUE TO ABSTRACT AND SIMPLIFY OUR IMAGE, WE ARE MOVING FURTHER AND FURTHER FROM THE "REAL" FACE OF THE PHOTO.
THIS WAY.

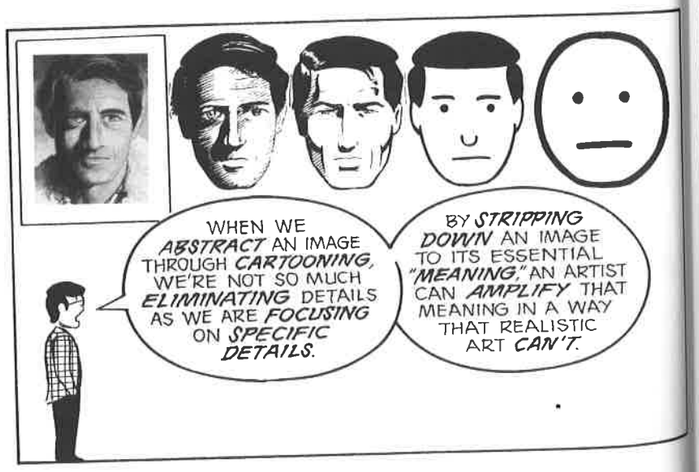

WHAT IS THE SECRET OF THE ICON WE CALL--
--THE CARTOON?
WAY.


WHY--
--ARE--
--WE--
--SO--
--INVOLVED?

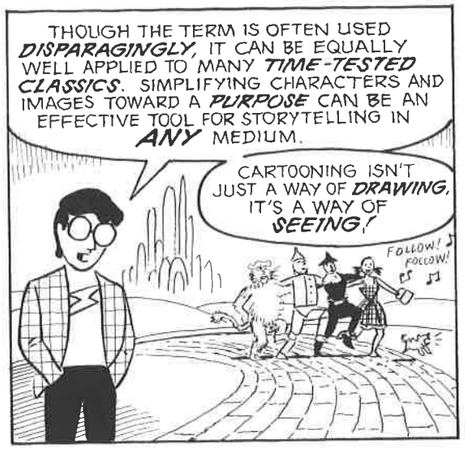

WHY WOULD ANYONE, YOUNG OR OLD, RESPOND TO A CARTOON AS MUCH OR MORE THAN A REALISTIC IMAGE?


WHY IS OUR CULTURE SO IN THRALL TO THE SIMPLIFIED REALITY OF THE CARTOON?

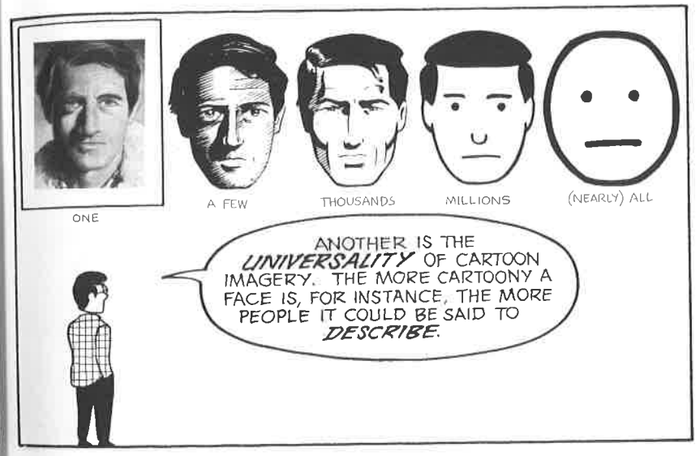

DEFINING THE CARTOON WOULD TAKE UP AS MUCH SPACE AS DEFINING COMICS, BUT FOR NOW, I'M GOING TO EXAMINE CARTOONING AS A FORM OF AMPLIFICATION THROUGH SIMPLIFICATION.


WHEN WE ABSTRACT AN IMAGE THROUGH CARTOONING, WE'RE NOT SO MUCH ELIMINATING DETAILS AS WE ARE FOCUSING ON SPECIFIC DETAILS.
BY STRIPPING DOWN AN IMAGE TO ITS ESSENTIAL "MEANING," AN ARTIST CAN AMPLIFY THAT MEANING IN A WAY THAT REALISTIC ART CAN'T.

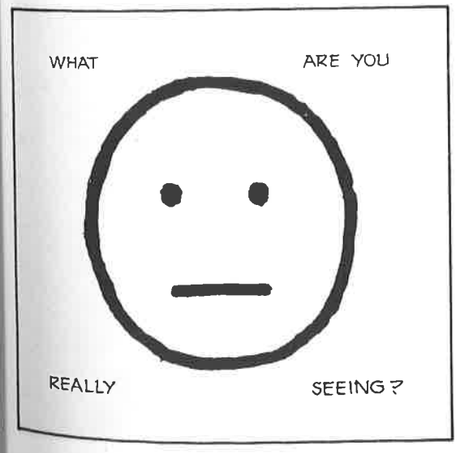
FILM CRITICS WILL SOMETIMES DESCRIBE A LIVE-ACTION FILM AS A "CARTOON" TO ACKNOWLEDGE THE STRIPPED-DOWN INTENSITY OF A SIMPLE STORY OR VISUAL STYLE.


THOUGH THE TERM IS OFTEN USED DISPARAGINGLY, IT CAN BE EQUALLY WELL APPLIED TO MANY TIME-TESTED CLASSICS. SIMPLIFYING CHARACTERS AND IMAGES TOWARD A PURPOSE CAN BE AN EFFECTIVE TOOL FOR STORYTELLING IN ANY MEDIUM.
CARTOONING ISN'T JUST A WAY OF DRAWING, IT'S A WAY OF SEEING!
FOLLOW! FOLLOW!

THE ABILITY OF CARTOONS TO FOCUS OUR ATTENTION ON AN IDEA IS, I THINK, AN IMPORTANT PART OF THEIR SPECIAL POWER, BOTH IN COMICS AND IN DRAWING GENERALLY.

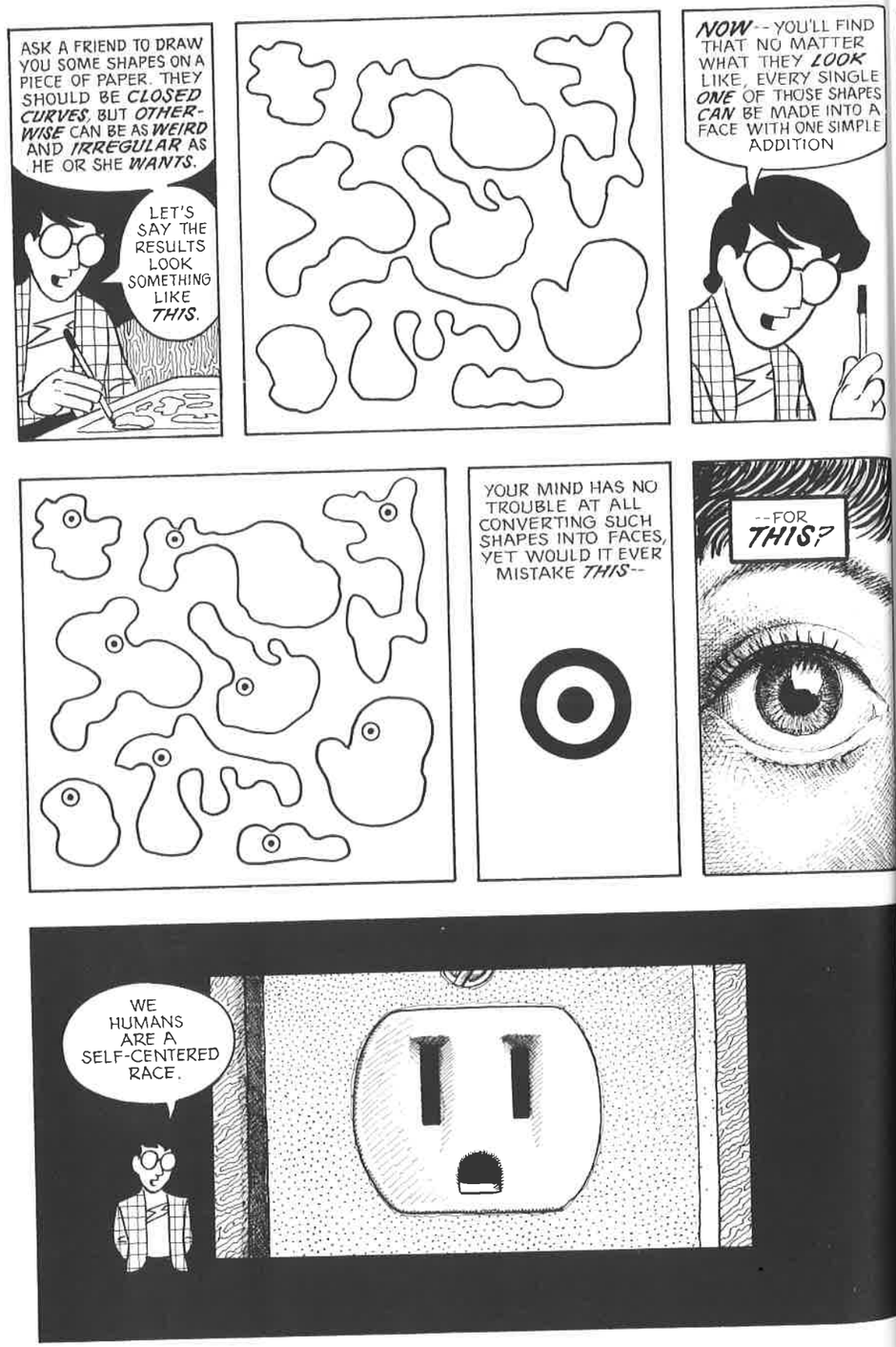

ONE
A FEW
THOUSANDS
MILLIONS
(NEARLY) ALL
ANOTHER IS THE UNIVERSALITY OF CARTOON IMAGERY. THE MORE CARTOONY A FACE IS, FOR INSTANCE, THE MORE PEOPLE IT COULD BE SAID TO DESCRIBE.

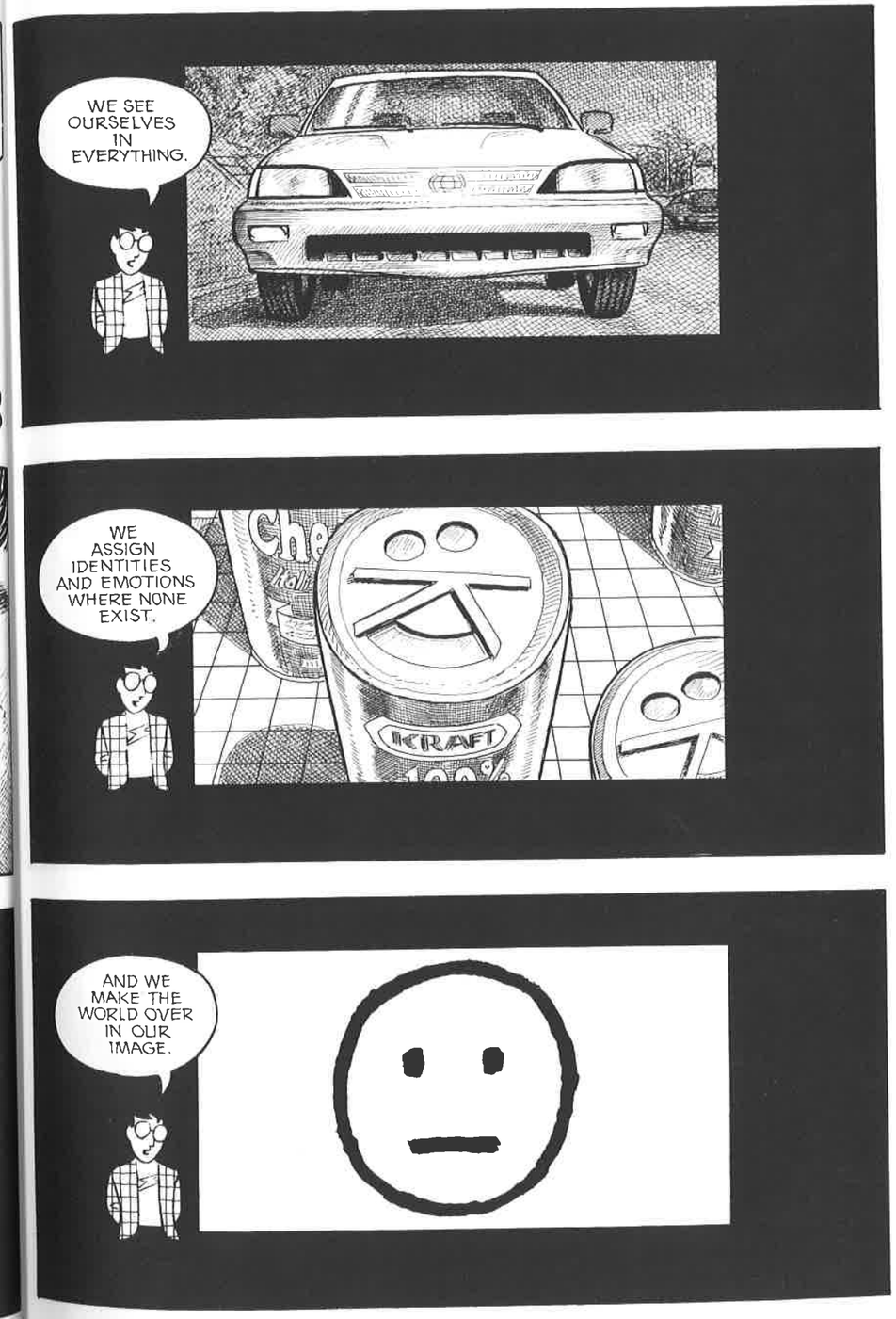
BUT I BELIEVE THERE'S SOMETHING MORE AT WORK IN OUR MINDS WHEN WE VIEW A CARTOON--ESPECIALLY OF A HUMAN FACE--WHICH WARRANTS FURTHER INVESTIGATION.


WHAT
ARE YOU
REALLY
SEEING?

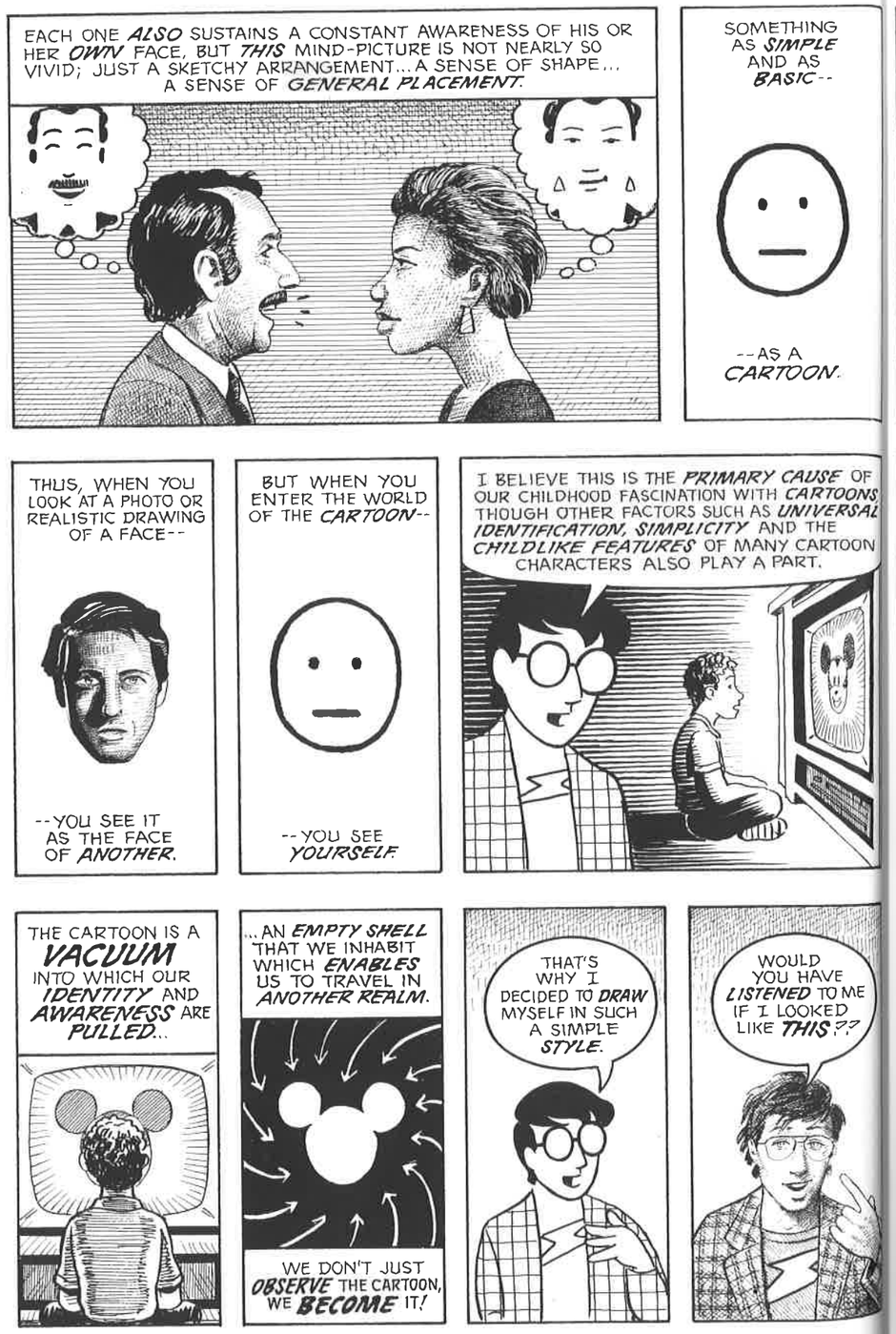
THE FACT THAT YOUR MIND IS CAPABLE OF TAKING A CIRCLE, TWO DOTS AND A LINE AND TURNING THEM INTO A FACE IS NOTHING SHORT OF INCREDIBLE!

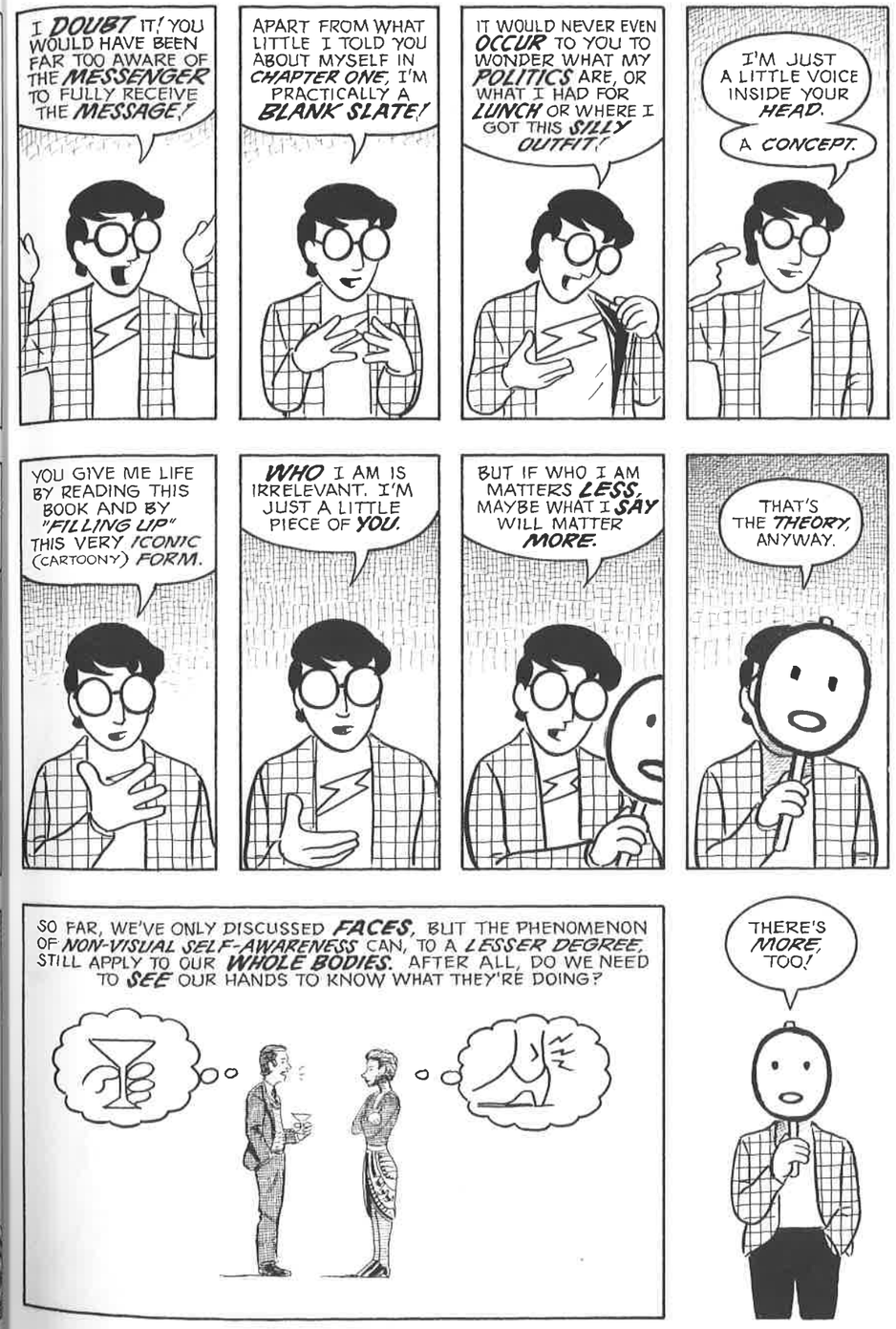
BUT STILL MORE INCREDIBLE IS THE FACT THAT YOU CANNOT AVOID SEEING A FACE HERE. YOUR MIND WON'T LET YOU!

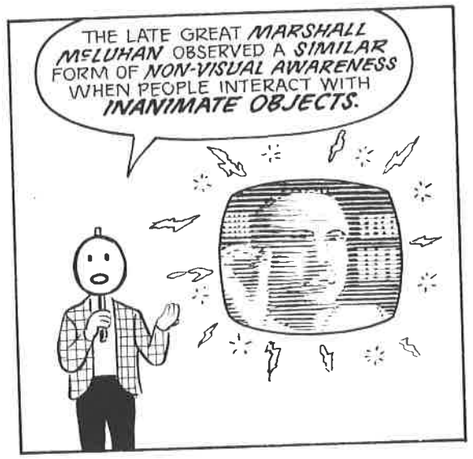

ASK A FRIEND TO DRAW YOU SOME SHAPES ON A PIECE OF PAPER. THEY SHOULD BE *CLOSED CURVES*, BUT *OTHERWISE* CAN BE AS *WEIRD* AND *IRREGULAR* AS HE OR SHE *WANTS*.
LET'S SAY THE RESULTS LOOK SOMETHING LIKE *THIS*.
NOW--YOU'LL FIND THAT NO MATTER WHAT THEY *LOOK* LIKE, EVERY SINGLE *ONE* OF THOSE SHAPES *CAN* BE MADE INTO A FACE WITH ONE SIMPLE ADDITION
YOUR MIND HAS NO TROUBLE AT ALL CONVERTING SUCH SHAPES INTO FACES, YET WOULD IT EVER MISTAKE *THIS*--
--FOR *THIS*?
WE HUMANS ARE A SELF-CENTERED RACE.

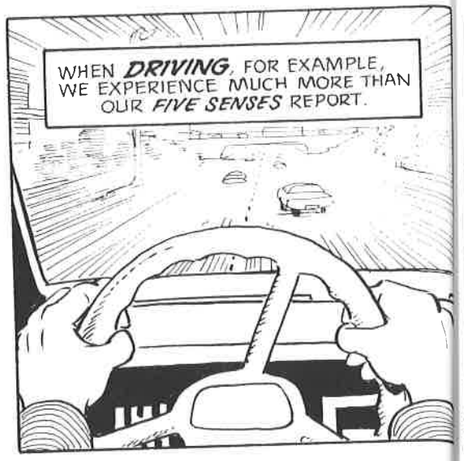

WE SEE OURSELVES IN EVERYTHING.
WE ASSIGN IDENTITIES AND EMOTIONS WHERE NONE EXIST.
KRAFT
AND WE MAKE THE WORLD OVER IN OUR IMAGE.

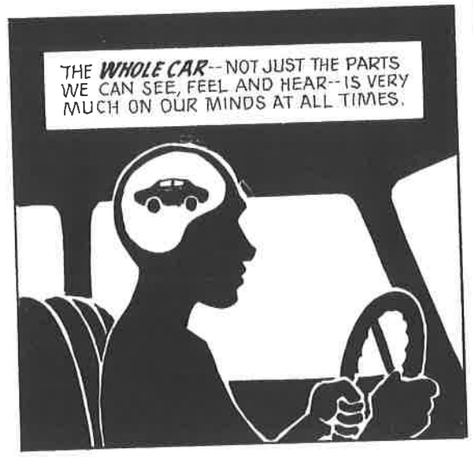
THINK OF YOUR FACE AS A MASK.
THAT'S WHAT IT *IS*, AFTER ALL.
ALL SET?
GOOD.
NOW, *SMILE*.
A MASK.
FACING *OUTWARD*.
WORN FROM THE DAY YOU WERE BORN.
SLAVE TO YOUR EVERY MENTAL COMMAND.
C'MON, NOBODY'S LOOKING.
GOOD. NOW, WHAT *CHANGED* WHEN YOU SMILED? WHAT DID YOU SEE?
NOTHING, RIGHT.
YET, YOU *KNOW* YOU SMILED! NOT JUST BECAUSE YOU FELT YOUR CHEEKS COMPRESS OR THE CRINKLING AROUND YOUR EYES!
SEEN BY EVERYONE YOU MEET.
BUT NEVER BY *YOU*.
OPEN ITS EYES NOW.
JUST *THINK* IT. THE MASK WILL OBEY.
YOU *KNOW* YOU SMILED BECAUSE YOU TRUSTED THIS MASK CALLED YOUR FACE TO *RESPOND*!
BUT THE FACE YOU SEE IN YOUR *MIND* IS NOT THE SAME AS *OTHERS* SEE!
WHEN TWO PEOPLE INTERRACT, THEY USUALLY LOOK DIRECTLY *AT* ONE ANOTHER, SEEING THEIR PARTNER'S FEATURES IN *VIVID DETAIL*.

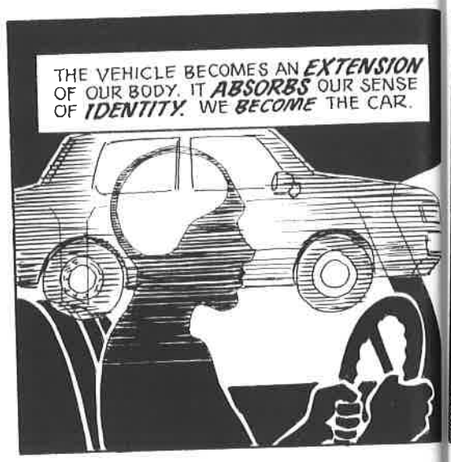

EACH ONE ALSO SUSTAINS A CONSTANT AWARENESS OF HIS OR HER OWN FACE, BUT THIS MIND-PICTURE IS NOT NEARLY SO VIVID; JUST A SKETCHY ARRANGEMENT... A SENSE OF SHAPE... A SENSE OF GENERAL PLACEMENT.
SOMETHING AS SIMPLE AND AS BASIC--
--AS A CARTOON.
THUS, WHEN YOU LOOK AT A PHOTO OR REALISTIC DRAWING OF A FACE--
--YOU SEE IT AS THE FACE OF ANOTHER.
BUT WHEN YOU ENTER THE WORLD OF THE CARTOON--
--YOU SEE YOURSELF.
I BELIEVE THIS IS THE PRIMARY CAUSE OF OUR CHILDHOOD FASCINATION WITH CARTOONS, THOUGH OTHER FACTORS SUCH AS UNIVERSAL IDENTIFICATION, SIMPLICITY AND THE CHILDLIKE FEATURES OF MANY CARTOON CHARACTERS ALSO PLAY A PART.
THE CARTOON IS A VACUUM INTO WHICH OUR IDENTITY AND AWARENESS ARE PULLED...
...AN EMPTY SHELL THAT WE INHABIT WHICH ENABLES US TO TRAVEL IN ANOTHER REALM.
WE DON'T JUST OBSERVE THE CARTOON, WE BECOME IT!
THAT'S WHY I DECIDED TO DRAW MYSELF IN SUCH A SIMPLE STYLE.
WOULD YOU HAVE LISTENED TO ME IF I LOOKED LIKE THIS??

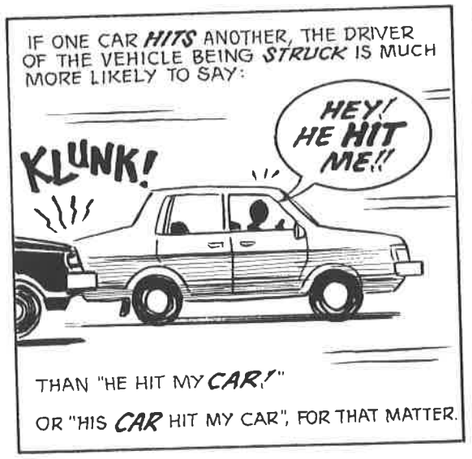

I DOUBT IT! YOU WOULD HAVE BEEN FAR TOO AWARE OF THE MESSENGER TO FULLY RECEIVE THE MESSAGE!
APART FROM WHAT LITTLE I TOLD YOU ABOUT MYSELF IN CHAPTER ONE, I'M PRACTICALLY A BLANK SLATE!
IT WOULD NEVER EVEN OCCUR TO YOU TO WONDER WHAT MY POLITICS ARE, OR WHAT I HAD FOR LUNCH OR WHERE I GOT THIS SILLY OUTFIT!
I'M JUST A LITTLE VOICE INSIDE YOUR HEAD.
A CONCEPT.
YOU GIVE ME LIFE BY READING THIS BOOK AND BY "FILLING UP" THIS VERY ICONIC (CARTOONY) FORM.
WHO I AM IS IRRELEVANT. I'M JUST A LITTLE PIECE OF YOU.
BUT IF WHO I AM MATTERS LESS, MAYBE WHAT I SAY WILL MATTER MORE.
THAT'S THE THEORY, ANYWAY.
SO FAR, WE'VE ONLY DISCUSSED FACES, BUT THE PHENOMENON OF NON-VISUAL SELF-AWARENESS CAN, TO A LESSER DEGREE, STILL APPLY TO OUR WHOLE BODIES. AFTER ALL, DO WE NEED TO SEE OUR HANDS TO KNOW WHAT THEY'RE DOING?
THERE'S MORE, TOO!

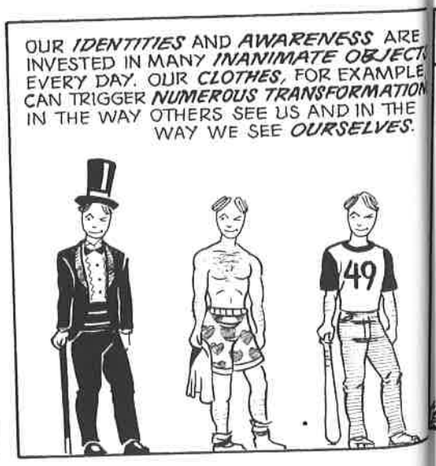

THE LATE GREAT MARSHALL McLUHAN OBSERVED A SIMILAR FORM OF NON-VISUAL AWARENESS WHEN PEOPLE INTERACT WITH INANIMATE OBJECTS.

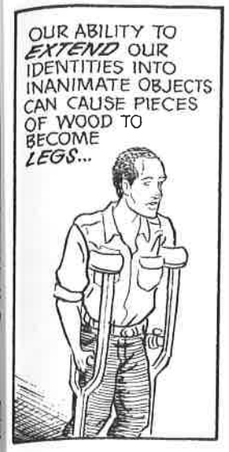

WHEN DRIVING, FOR EXAMPLE, WE EXPERIENCE MUCH MORE THAN OUR FIVE SENSES REPORT.

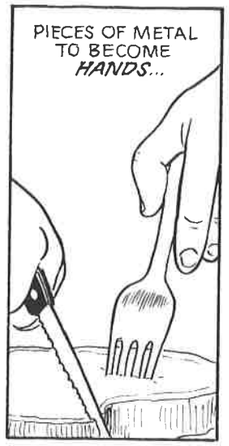

THE WHOLE CAR--NOT JUST THE PARTS WE CAN SEE, FEEL AND HEAR--IS VERY MUCH ON OUR MINDS AT ALL TIMES.


THE VEHICLE BECOMES AN EXTENSION OF OUR BODY. IT ABSORBS OUR SENSE OF IDENTITY. WE BECOME THE CAR.


IF ONE CAR HITS ANOTHER, THE DRIVER OF THE VEHICLE BEING STRUCK IS MUCH MORE LIKELY TO SAY:
KLUNK!
HEY! HE HIT ME!!
THAN "HE HIT MY CAR!"
OR "HIS CAR HIT MY CAR", FOR THAT MATTER.


OUR IDENTITIES AND AWARENESS ARE INVESTED IN MANY INANIMATE OBJECTS EVERY DAY. OUR CLOTHES, FOR EXAMPLE, CAN TRIGGER NUMEROUS TRANSFORMATIONS IN THE WAY OTHERS SEE US AND IN THE WAY WE SEE OURSELVES.
49

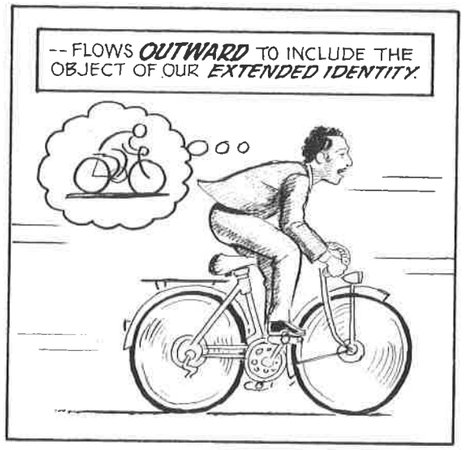

OUR ABILITY TO EXTEND OUR IDENTITIES INTO INANIMATE OBJECTS CAN CAUSE PIECES OF WOOD TO BECOME LEGS...

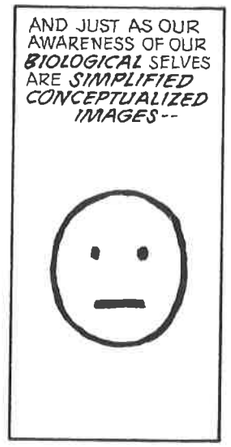

PIECES OF METAL TO BECOME HANDS...

PIECES OF PLASTIC TO BECOME EARS...

PIECES OF GLASS TO BECOME EYES.

AND IN EVERY CASE, OUR CONSTANT AWARENESS OF SELF--


--FLOWS OUTWARD TO INCLUDE THE OBJECT OF OUR EXTENDED IDENTITY.

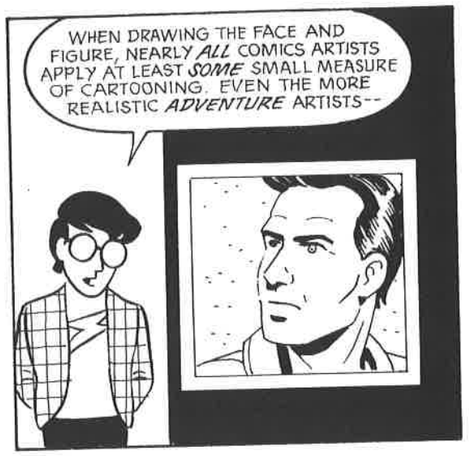

AND JUST AS OUR AWARENESS OF OUR BIOLOGICAL SELVES ARE SIMPLIFIED CONCEPTUALIZED IMAGES--

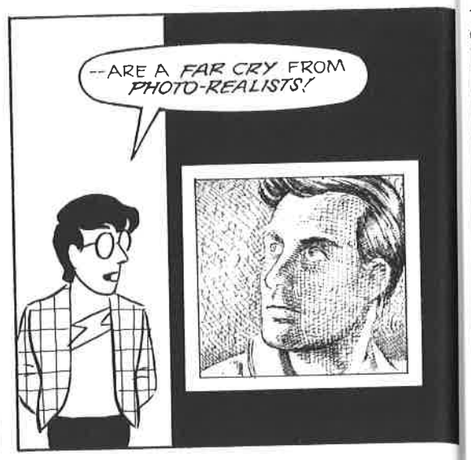
--SO TOO IS OUR AWARENESS OF THESE EXTENSIONS GREATLY SIMPLIFIED.

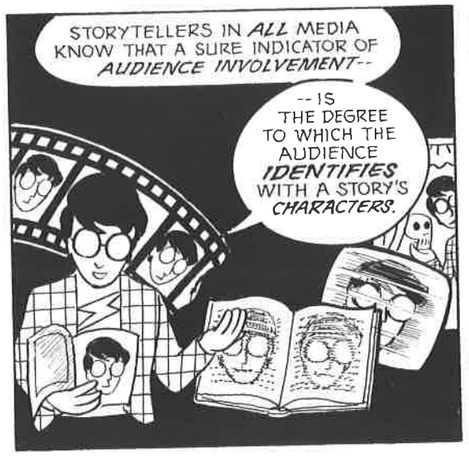
ALL THE THINGS WE EXPERIENCE IN LIFE CAN BE SEPARATED INTO TWO REALMS, THE REALM OF THE CONCEPT--
--AND THE REALM OF THE SENSES.

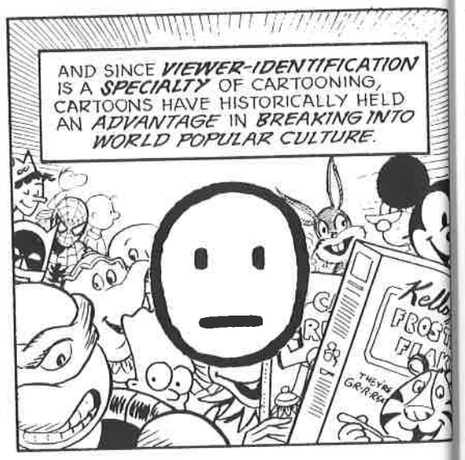
OUR IDENTITIES BELONG *PERMANENTLY* TO THE *CONCEPTUAL* WORLD. THEY CAN'T BE *SEEN, HEARD, SMELLED, TOUCHED* OR *TASTED*. THEY'RE MERELY *IDEAS*. AND *EVERYTHING ELSE*--AT THE START--BELONGS TO THE *SENSUAL WORLD*, THE WORLD *OUTSIDE* OF US.
GRADUALLY WE REACH *BEYOND* OURSELVES.
WE ENCOUNTER THE *SIGHT, SMELL, TOUCH, TASTE* AND *SOUND* OF OUR OWN BODIES.
AND OF THE WORLD *AROUND* US.
AND SOON WE DISCOVER THAT OBJECTS OF THE *PHYSICAL WORLD* CAN *ALSO* CROSS OVER--
--AND POSSESS IDENTITIES OF THEIR OWN.
OR, AS OUR *EXTENSIONS*--
--BEGIN TO GLOW--
--WITH THE LIFE--

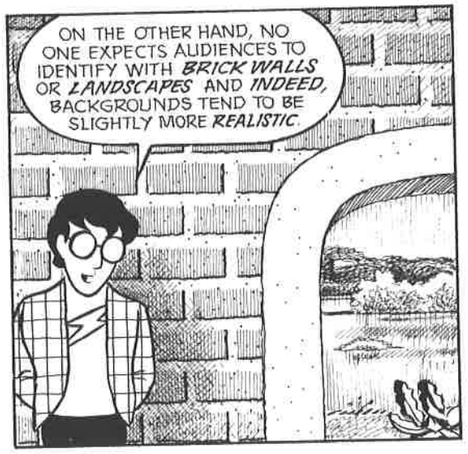
--WE *LEND* TO THEM.
BY DE-EMPHASIZING THE *APPEARANCE* OF THE *PHYSICAL* WORLD IN FAVOR OF THE *IDEA* OF FORM, THE CARTOON PLACES ITSELF IN THE WORLD OF *CONCEPTS*.
THROUGH TRADITIONAL *REALISM*, THE COMICS ARTIST CAN PORTRAY THE WORLD *WITHOUT*--
--AND THROUGH THE *CARTOON*, THE WORLD *WITHIN*.
WHEN CARTOONS ARE USED *THROUGHOUT* A STORY, THE *WORLD* OF THAT STORY MAY SEEM TO *PULSE WITH LIFE*.
INANIMATE OBJECTS MAY SEEM TO POSSESS *SEPARATE IDENTITIES* SO THAT IF ONE *JUMPED UP* AND STARTED *SINGING* IT WOULDN'T FEEL OUT OF PLACE.
BUT IN EMPHASIZING THE *CONCEPTS* OF OBJECTS OVER THEIR *PHYSICAL APPEARANCE*, MUCH HAS TO BE *OMITTED*.
IF AN ARTIST WANTS TO PORTRAY THE BEAUTY AND COMPLEXITY OF THE *PHYSICAL WORLD*--
--REALISM OF *SOME* SORT IS GOING TO PLAY A PART.

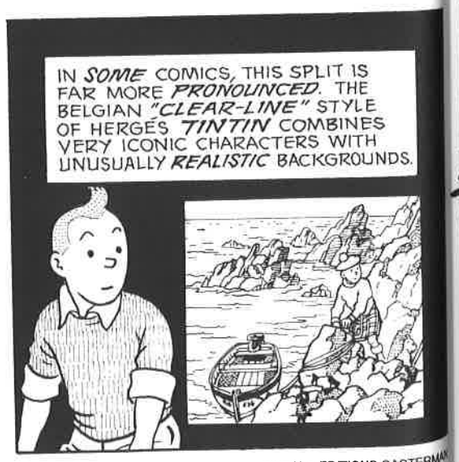












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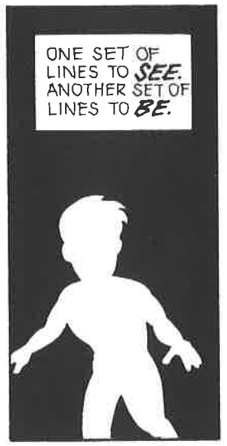

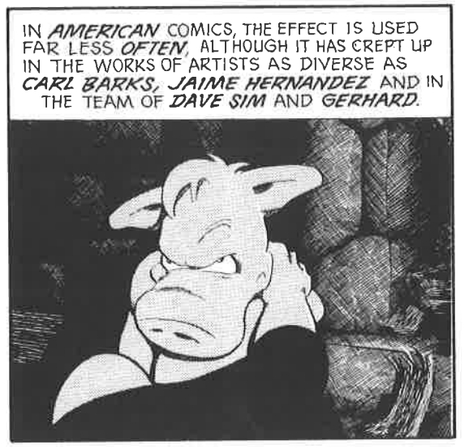

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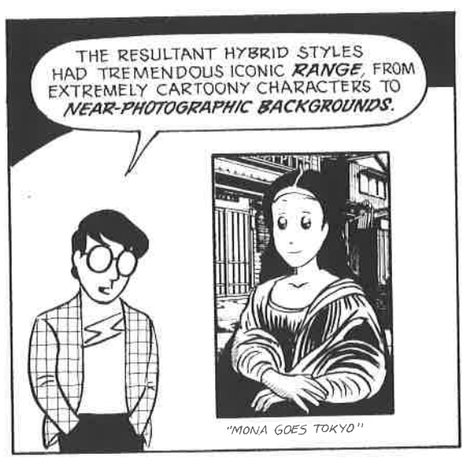

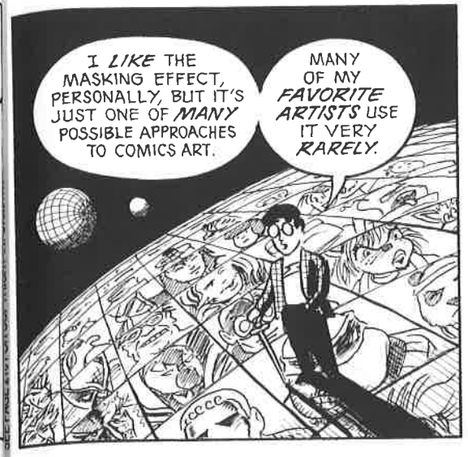

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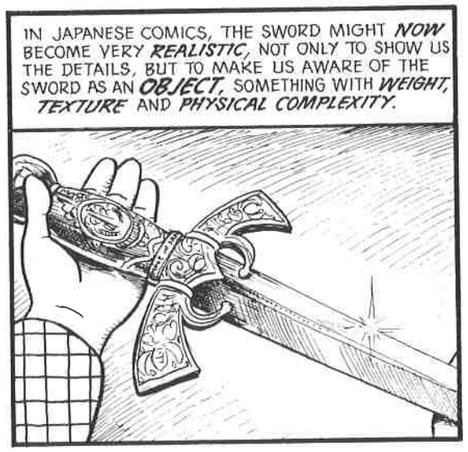

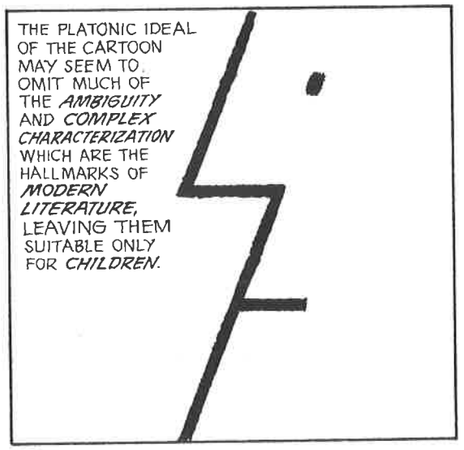

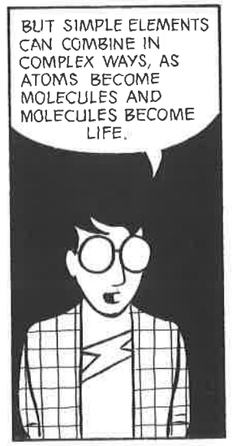
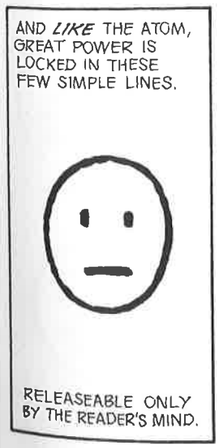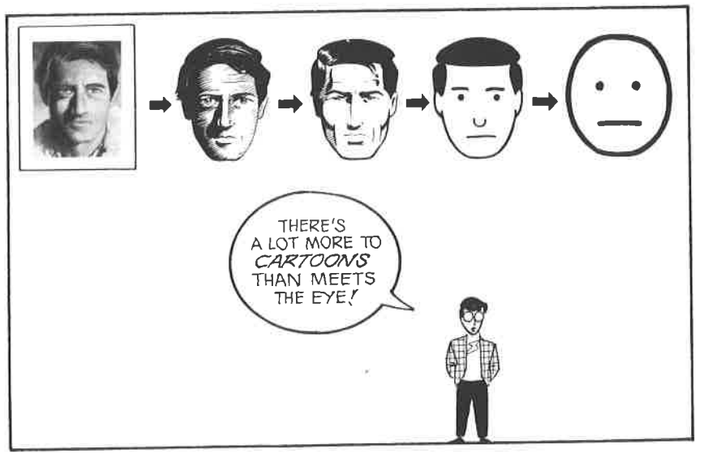
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